Astana IT University — MT-2601M

Assessment Lab

What does a grade actually tell us?

> Fair assessment requires clear outcomes, relevant tasks, useful feedback, transparent criteria, and reasoned flexibility.
>
> Our evidence supports improving assessment. It does not establish that abolishing grades is the best solution.

The assessment problem

A number can record a result. On its own, it cannot explain what a student understands, how a decision was made, or what to do next. We look behind the grade to ask how assessment can better support learning.

Our approach

We synthesised five scholarly publications, five group members' reflective notes, and three external interview accounts. We compared what research can establish with how particular students experience assessment.

P1, P2, and P3 answered six common questions. Their Russian responses are paraphrased in the essay. These individual perspectives are not a representative survey.

Five evidence themes

01 / Competence

Framework

Align the intended learning outcome, teaching activity, and assessment task. Recall alone cannot show every kind of understanding. **Course improvement and the accuracy of its grades are separate questions.** (Biggs, 1996)

02 / Motivation

Research finding

Grades versus no feedback showed higher achievement but poorer motivation; comments generally outperformed grades on both outcomes. **School evidence does not directly establish effects in higher education.** (Koenka et al., 2021)

03 / Feedback & peers

Research finding

Feedback can support learning, but effects vary with its information. Peer assessment shows a performance benefit, not proof of emotional safety. **The two syntheses study different interventions; their effects are not interchangeable.** (Wisniewski et al., 2020; Double et al., 2020)

04 / Transparent criteria

Research finding

Rubrics showed a positive pooled effect on performance after adjusting for publication bias. Wider benefits were less conclusive. **A rubric's presence does not establish that every decision is fair.** (Panadero et al., 2023)

05 / Individual circumstances

Personal accounts → proposal

All three interviewees support considering serious circumstances. We propose reasoned accommodations while keeping the learning outcome clear. **The cited meta-analyses do not directly test the fairness of these accommodations.** (P1–P3; Shpringer, 2026; Sagatove, 2026)

Limitations

Five selected publications, five reflections, and three interview accounts cannot establish how common these experiences are or predict the effects of reform at our university. Studies differ in setting, intervention, and outcome. Personal accounts do not verify institutional policies. Our proposed teaching practices and this demonstration have not been tested by this project.

Individual perspectives

P1: Values strict teaching and improvement through Public Speaking, yet describes an unfamiliar football task as confusing. Wants creativity recognised and warns about corruption.

P2: Values explicit criteria and flexibility in how knowledge is demonstrated. Favours retaining grades while increasing practical work and feedback.

P3: Questions point chasing, one-off examinations, and equal group marks for unequal contributions. Favours retaining grades with more practical work and feedback.

Proposed teaching practices

1. Start with the intended learning. For evaluating educational arguments, ask students to analyse a claim and justify their evaluation with evidence. Align practice and assessment with that outcome.

2. Make reasoning observable. Combine a written critique with a brief explanation. Let students choose accessible topics while using common standards for evidence, alternatives, and clarity.

3. Build in a feedback and revision cycle. Comment on a draft, support peer discussion, and give students a chance to revise. Ask which comments they used rather than assuming all feedback helps.

4. Explain decisions and accommodations. Share criteria, record group contributions, offer a written clarification route, and explain flexibility without disclosing private circumstances.

Evaluate a classroom trial using initial and revised work against the same criteria, alongside students' experiences of barriers. Improvement would be local evidence; practice and extra study could also explain it, so a simple before-and-after comparison would not establish causation.

You are the assessor

This fictional classroom example and illustrative rubric were created for the website. Visitors give an initial grade, read criteria and feedback, rate three criteria from 0 to 4, and compare their decisions. There is no predetermined correct grade. A changed grade does not prove improved fairness or learning; criteria make the reasoning behind a decision more explicit.

Task: Should universities replace numerical grades with written feedback? Give a reasoned answer, use evidence, and consider another perspective.

Fictional response: "Universities should remove grades because students only study for points. Practical projects show skills better than exams. Teachers should give comments instead, because comments help students improve."

Weights: Clarity 30%; evidence 40%; alternative perspectives 30%. Each criterion is rated 0–4. Sum (rating ÷ 4 × weight) for a result out of 100.

Feedback: Keep the clear position; qualify broad claims; add relevant evidence; address another perspective.

References

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Poster contributions

Kamaliden Akmaral: Co-wrote the group essay and contributed a reflective note on disciplined practice versus room for creativity. For the poster, shaped the central argument and conclusion wording and proofread the final content.

Saparbek Makhambet: Built the Assessment Lab website and its interactive assessor activity. Collected the P1–P3 interview accounts with Rakhat and wrote the Week 6 reflective note on assessing analysis rather than recall.

Sagatove Madiyar: Wrote reflective notes on workplace onboarding, Bildung, and whether consistency equals fairness. For the poster, drafted the competence and circumstances lenses and the "What this evidence cannot tell us" limitations panel.

Shpringer Artyom: Wrote the reflective note on teaching dilemmas and trust, used for the peer-assessment and practical-wisdom arguments. Finalised the website: contribution records, content review, testing, and the published build.

Yesmukhametov Rakhat: Collected the P1–P3 interview accounts with Makhambet and paraphrased them for the "Three voices" section. Wrote the reflective note on grade ceilings and administrative expectations used in the motivation lens.